



Burkina Faso



Area 105,869 sq miles
(274,200 sq km)
Population 17 million
Capital Ouagadougou
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 52 years



◀ TRADITIONAL DRESS

Traditionally, women in Burkina wear long cotton skirts that are wrapped at the waist, along with matching tops. Shown here is a mother carrying her baby on her back.

Landlocked in West Africa, Burkina (officially called Burkina Faso) gained independence from France in 1960. Most of Burkina lies on the arid edge of the Sahara Desert known as the Sahel. Following independence, it was ruled by military dictators until 1991, when it became a multiparty democracy. However, it is now ruled by a former military dictator, Blaise Compaoré, who was elected president in 1991. It has large mineral deposits such as gold, antimony, marble, manganese, silver, and zinc. Despite this, Burkina's economy remains largely agricultural.

Ghana



Area 92,100 sq miles
(238,540 sq km)
Population 25 million
Capital Accra
Currency Cedi
Official language English
Life expectancy 60 years



Ghana was the first West African nation to gain independence from its colonial power, Britain, in 1957. It is Africa's second largest gold producer and is a major exporter of cocoa. Ghana has made good progress in reducing poverty, thanks to a growing economy—it has a well-developed industrial base and started producing oil in 2011.

Nigeria



Area 356,669 sq miles
(923,768 sq km)
Population 162 million
Capital Abuja
Currency Naira
Official language English
Life expectancy 47 years



Africa's most populous country, the Federal Republic of Nigeria gained its independence from the UK in 1960. Its terrain varies from tropical rainforest and swamps in the south to savanna in the north. After a series of military regimes, Nigeria now has an elected government. It has a strongly growing economy, boosted by the fact that Nigeria

Togo



Area 21,925 sq miles
(56,785 sq km)
Population 6.2 million
Capital Lomé
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 58 years



Togo is sandwiched between Ghana and Benin in West Africa. Its center is forested, surrounded by savanna lands in the north and south. The port of Lomé is an important center for West African trade. The "Nana Benz," the market women of Lomé, control the retail trade. However, political power is held only by the men.

Benin



Area 43,843 sq miles
(112,620 sq km)
Population 9.1 million
Capital Porto-Novo
Currency CFA franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 56 years



Formerly the kingdom of Dahomey, Benin was under French rule until it gained independence in 1960. Ending 17 years of one-party Communist rule, Benin became a multiparty democracy in 1990. Benin has 42 different ethnic groups. About 50 percent of the population follow indigenous beliefs, including voodoo.

is one of the world's top oil producers. However, oil industry pollution in the Niger Delta—the origin of most of Nigeria's oil production—is a major concern. Natural gas, coal, tin, and iron are some of the other mineral resources found here. More than half the country is poor: Ethnic violence from 1999 to 2003 drove about 800,000 people out of their homes, adding to Nigeria's poverty levels.

► LAGOS, NIGERIA

Shown here is the skyline of Lagos, the most populous city and the financial heart of Nigeria. Lagos is one of the fastest-growing cities in Africa.

